young men.

The rest, as they say, is history …

Here is one of the first interviews that Kiran gave as a police officer. It is indicative of her attitude to the service, which hasn't changed once over the years despite all the upheavals and the storms …

IPS Woman Believes in Public Service

Mrs Kiran Bedi, the first woman to enter the Indian Police Service, is used to limelight. An outstanding lawn tennis player, she always wanted to do 'something outstanding', as she put it in an interview here today.

'That was why,' she explained, 'I did not take something ordinary. I had to have a challenging job.' The Indian Administrative Service and the Indian Foreign Service were 'flooded with' girls.

Asked if she wanted IPS to be flooded with girls, Mrs Bedi said she would strongly recommend the service to women who are physically fit and who are capable of independent thinking.

Speaking for herself, she said she had always been encouraged to think independently by her parents and the decision to go for IPS was also entirely hers.

She was confident that the IPS would give her a chance to show her qualities of taking up challenges and overcoming them to her satisfaction.

As such, she 'loved public service' and believed that the IPS was the ideal public service as far as she was concerned.

Mrs Bedi, who married an Amritsar businessman last year, said it was possible for her to join the IPS because her husband encouraged her. 'He is one of the most encouraging husbands one can encounter,' she added, rather shyly.

How do they plan to bring up the family? She did not think they would have much difficulty in this respect as 'neither of us has any inhibitions' about doing any sort of job.

As she has [been allocated] the Union Territory cadre, Mrs Bedi knows it means staying away from home for long periods. She hopes that her initial postings will be nearer home. They plan to have a child after a year or two.

Playing tennis ever since her school days in Amritsar, she had made her name (née Peshawaria) hit the headlines of sports pages quiet frequently. In fact, her strenuous tennis sessions have helped her to take the rigorous physical training of the IPS course at Mt Abu.

She has been selected along with two other Indian women players to play against Ceylon [as Sri Lanka was formerly known] in Colombo next month. Her job in the IPS, she believes, will help her in promoting tennis among women at the district level.

A topper in MA (political science) from Punjab University, Chandigarh, Mrs Bedi thinks women officers will be an asset to the police force as they are 'basically sympathetic and loving'.

(*The Hindustan Times*, 20 July 1973)

Kiran continued to work from outside her home state and her city of birth as she was allocated the union territory as her cadre. This situation meant that she would have no opportunity to serve in her own home state. It also clearly meant three homes for her: Her own, her husband's and her parents.